

What Bookly sells

Before the price list, the product. What a salon owner in Accra is actually buying, what it replaces, and the one thing missing that would make it obvious.

Revised September 2026 (2nd) · written for go-to-market · supersedes earlier plan-tier drafts

01

The answer in one word

You are selling a receptionist — for WhatsApp *and* Instagram.

Not software. Not "AI automation". Not "the WhatsApp Business API".

That reframe is not cosmetic — it sets the price anchor.

Your customer is not comparing Bookly to other booking apps, because they don't use one. They are comparing it to **hiring someone**, or to **the money already walking out of the door**. A receptionist in Accra costs a real salary every month, takes lunch, and goes home at six. Bookly is a fraction of that and never stops answering.

It is also a sentence a barber understands in three seconds. "A receptionist for your WhatsApp and Instagram" lands. "Multi-tenant omnichannel booking automation" does not.

02

The seven jobs it does

In the order the customer feels them, not the order they were built.

- 1 Answers while you're working.** Mid-haircut you cannot reply, and that customer messages the next salon down the road. The assistant replies instantly, at any hour.
- 2 Only offers times you are genuinely free.** It checks your opening hours, your blackout dates, your existing bookings and how many customers you can serve at once. It cannot promise something your diary can't honour.
- 3 Takes money before they arrive.** A deposit by Mobile Money or card. The slot is held for 30 minutes and released if nobody pays.
- 4 Chases the no-show.** Automatic reminders before the appointment.
- 5 Keeps one diary.** Replaces the notebook and the "I think I have someone at two".

- 6 **Handles the money and the messages for them.** No payment gateway account, no SMS gateway account, no API keys, nothing to paste from another website. Customers pay Bookly, and the owner sends their earnings to their own Mobile Money whenever they want.
- 7 **Answers wherever they market.** Instagram DMs and Facebook Messenger as well as WhatsApp, with the same assistant and the same diary behind all three. Salons advertise on Instagram; that is where "how much for box braids?" already arrives.

And one thing it does for the owner rather than the customer: your staff see only the last four digits of any number.

The customer list is the most valuable thing in the account. Staff can reply, and can reveal a single number when they genuinely need it — each reveal recorded. The book does not leave with them.

Job 1 wins the customer. It's the pain they feel every working day, and it's what makes them try it.

Jobs 3 and 4 keep the customer. That's where the money is, and it's the reason they're still paying in month six.

03

Who it is for

FITS	WHY
Appointment businesses	Salons, barbers, nail and lash techs, spas, dental and aesthetic clinics, physios, tutors, trainers, photographers, mechanics. Anything where time is the inventory.
One to eight people	Big enough to lose bookings while busy, too small to employ a receptionist. Multi-chair shops say how many customers they serve at once, so all their capacity is bookable.
Already living in WhatsApp	Customers message them there today. Bookly improves an existing habit rather than asking for a new one.
Selling on Instagram	Where most salons, barbers and nail techs actually advertise. Instagram and Messenger cost nothing per message and need no card at all.
Anyone who has never set up software	The two hardest steps — taking card and Mobile Money payments, and sending text reminders — need no account, no key and no setup. That is the single biggest reason this reaches people other tools do not.
Anyone with staff	Contact masking means employees can work the inbox without being able to copy out the customer book.

DOESN'T FIT (YET)	WHY
Walk-in-only trade	No appointments, nothing to book.
Businesses needing "book with a named person"	There is no per-staff booking yet. A customer can be told how many slots are free, but cannot ask for Ama specifically.
Mobile-Money-only businesses <i>on WhatsApp</i>	Meta bills WhatsApp messages to a card or PayPal and does not accept MoMo. They can run fully on Instagram and Messenger, which Meta does not charge for. Note this is only about Meta's own messaging fee — taking customer payments and getting paid out both work on Mobile Money throughout.

What you are really competing with

Not other SaaS. Your honest competitive set is:

ALTERNATIVE	WHAT IT COSTS THEM
A notebook and their own thumbs	Free, and it mostly works — which is exactly why "cheaper than X" is a weak pitch. You need "earns you more than X."
A human receptionist	A monthly salary. This is your true price anchor for a shop with a few chairs.
Answering DMs manually	Lost bookings and lost evenings. The status quo you are displacing.

None of those charge a monthly fee. So the price has to be justified by **recovered revenue**, never by a feature comparison.

The arithmetic that sells it

The pitch writes itself, as long as it's in their numbers rather than yours.

Three no-shows a week	× GHS 50
Per month	≈ GHS 600 lost
Bookings missed while mid-service	harder to count, usually worse
Anything priced below that	is obviously worth paying

Figures are illustrative — the point is the shape. Ask an owner for their own two numbers and the maths does the selling.

The hole in the story

THE GAP WORTH CLOSING FIRST

The product cannot currently prove it works. The dashboard returns four counts — total bookings, today's bookings, active chats, total customers. Not one cedi figure. No deposits collected, no bookings taken outside working hours, no reminders sent.

You are asking people to pay for value they cannot see. A single panel changes that:

This month: GHS 2,400 in deposits collected · 43 bookings taken while you were busy · 118 messages answered for you

That one panel does three jobs at once. It **justifies any price without you arguing**. It is **what the owner screenshots** and sends to another salon owner, which is your cheapest growth channel. And it is **what stops them cancelling in month three**, when the novelty has worn off and they've forgotten what it was like before.

If only one thing gets built off the back of this brief, it should be this.

07

What you are no longer selling

Messages. You don't supply them — Meta does, and bills the business directly on WhatsApp. On Instagram and Messenger nobody is billed at all. Selling "5,000 messages" is what creates the confusion of two bills from two companies, and it undersells the two channels that are simply free.

But you now DO supply two things worth naming

Taking payments. Customers pay Bookly, the money is credited to the owner, and they send it to their own Mobile Money when they want it. They never create a Paystack account or touch an API key.

Sending text reminders. Same arrangement on Bookly's own SMS account.

These are the two steps that used to end the conversation. They are worth saying out loud in the pitch, because every competitor still asks the owner to go and get a key.

Turn it into a trust line instead, the way the stronger players do:

"You pay Meta's own rates directly. We don't add a cent on top."

A transparency advantage, not an apology.

How to say it

One positioning statement, then the same idea cut to length for each place it has to live.

Bookly is a receptionist for your WhatsApp and Instagram. It answers customers when you're busy, books them into times you're really free, and takes a deposit so they actually show up.

IN PERSON	"You know when you're cutting and your phone keeps buzzing? It answers for you — and takes the deposit."
LANDING HERO	Never lose a booking because you were busy.
FOR INSTAGRAM SELLERS	Your DMs already ask "how much?" and "are you free Saturday?" — this answers both, and books them.
WHATSAPP BIO	Book me here — replies instantly, even when I'm with a client.
OBJECTION: "I REPLY MYSELF"	"At two in the morning? On Sunday? While you're mid-service?"
OBJECTION: "TOO EXPENSIVE"	"How many no-shows last week? What do you charge?" Then wait.
ON SETUP	"You don't need a Paystack account or anything technical. Customers pay through us, and you send it to your MoMo whenever you want."
OBJECTION: "I DON'T TRUST STAFF WITH IT"	"They only see the last four digits. You see everything, and every time someone looks up a number it's recorded."

What the story needs next

BUILD	WHICH PART OF THE PITCH IT UNLOCKS
The value panel	Turns "it helps" into a number. Justifies price, drives referral, prevents churn. Still the highest leverage by a distance, and still not built.
Ask for a phone on Instagram	Small but blocking. An Instagram customer has no phone number, and a booking needs one for the deposit and the SMS reminder. Until the assistant asks, an Instagram booking cannot complete.
Per-staff booking	"Book with Ama." Opens shops with several stylists and is the natural reason for a bigger business to pay more.
A local billing rail for WhatsApp	Instagram and Messenger already work without a card. This one only unblocks WhatsApp for Mobile-Money businesses.
Paystack aggregator approval	Collecting on behalf of other businesses needs written sign-off, and payouts need Registered business status. Both block real money, neither blocks building.

Positioning brief, September 2026. Supersedes the earlier plan-tier drafts – pricing should be set after the value panel exists, so the number can be argued from evidence rather than from guesswork. Currency figures are illustrative. Product facts reflect the codebase as of this date. Instagram and Messenger are built but cannot go live until Meta approves the messaging permissions through App Review. Payment collection and payouts are built but not live: they need written aggregator approval from Paystack and Registered business status.